

Strategic Modeling — Module 02: Agents —

Discussion Questions

20 questions on stakeholder modeling, competitor analysis, and theory of mind in strategy.

1. Why does effective strategy require modeling competitors' beliefs and not just their capabilities?
2. Netflix built a fundamentally different model of customer needs than Blockbuster. How could Blockbuster have detected this model divergence earlier?
3. How does "theory of mind" (modeling how others model you) create strategic advantage?
4. When a competitor's behavior surprises you, what does that reveal about your model of them?
5. How would you structure a competitor analysis that goes beyond capabilities to include assumptions, intentions, and blind spots?
6. Customers are inference agents. How does this change marketing strategy compared to viewing customers as passive recipients?
7. How do game-theoretic concepts (Nash equilibrium, dominant strategy) relate to Active Inference?
8. When should you try to change a stakeholder's generative model versus adapt your strategy to their existing model?
9. How does the accuracy of your customer model affect pricing strategy?
10. What are the ethical boundaries of strategic stakeholder modeling?
11. Select a competitor and build a four-quadrant analysis: capabilities, intentions, assumptions, blind spots.
12. Map the generative model of a key customer segment. What are they inferring? What uncertainties drive their decisions?
13. Design a system for continuously updating your model of a key competitor.
14. How would you model a regulator as an inference agent? What are they optimizing for?

15. Compare how a startup and an established firm model their stakeholder landscape differently.
16. When multiple competitors are modeling each other simultaneously, what dynamics emerge?
17. How do cultural differences affect the accuracy of stakeholder modeling across international markets?
18. Design a "stakeholder model audit" that tests the accuracy of your organization's assumptions about key stakeholders.
19. When is it advantageous to be unpredictable to competitors? When is predictability better?
20. How does your organization's model of its customer differ from the customer's model of themselves? What consequences does this gap have?